He did offer a suggestion for how Israel could circumvent the law, by arguing that the West Bank was in essence still part of Mandatory Palestine, which had never been officially divided into two political entities. But “in truth,” he added, “even certain actions by Israel are inconsistent with the claim that the [West] Bank is not occupied territory.” Around the same time, four officials from the Mossad, the foreign intelligence service, went out to survey Palestinian public opinion. They too returned with a clear recommendation: Israel should hasten to establish a Palestinian state, they wrote, because “the vast majority of West Bank leaders, including the most extreme among them, are prepared at this time to reach a permanent peace agreement.”

The Labor government, led by Levi Eshkol, ignored their advice and allowed Porat to establish Kfar Etzion anyway. “The secular Labor leaders, themselves former pioneers, could not resist,” Akiva Eldar and Idith Zertal wrote in *Lords of the Land*, their detailed history of the settler movement. “They perceived the blue-eyed fighter, paratrooper, and religious settler of the land [Porat] as a new incarnation and avatar of the soldier-tiller of the land, the cherished icon of national movements that fight for territory.”[2]

The following year, a group of Israeli Jews moved into a hotel in Hebron. They pretended to be Swiss tourists celebrating Passover, and then refused to leave. Eshkol decided not to force them out, and thus Kiryat Arba was born, the first of five Israeli settlements in and around Hebron. It remains the only Palestinian city with a settler presence inside its borders, and its residents are among the West Bank’s most ideological, a major source of friction to this day.

From there, the settlements grew in fits and starts—slowly at first, during the next decade of Labor rule, and then rapidly once Menachem Begin brought Likud to power in 1977. Netanyahu, despite his right-wing rhetoric, has taken a middle road. The settler population has grown rapidly during his term in office: up by 37 per cent over eight years, to a total of 385,000 people, compared to 14 per cent growth for Israel as a whole. (A roughly equal number of Israelis live in occupied East Jerusalem, but they are a very different group, ideologically and legally; we will return to them later.) Much of this, however, is “natural growth”—settlers having children. New construction is relatively slow. Except for 2013, developers broke ground on fewer than 2,000 new homes per year or “construction starts”, as they’re